A SATIRICAL STORY

Ai's Untapped *Talent*



The things we might have discovered about Ai had we not been bound to our expectations

With case notes by Dr. Miriam Voss,
a fictional consulting therapist to the community.

Preface

This book offers a gentle introduction to artificial intelligence (AI) from a psychological perspective. It begins with the expectations, habits, and small acts of self-protection we bring to something unfamiliar.

We quickly decide what an assistant is good for. A fluent answer may earn too much trust; the memory of one mistake may outlast many improvements. We welcome agreement, resist correction, and sometimes mistake a few familiar questions for a thorough investigation.

The story follows a printer learning to recognize these habits in himself. As his questions change, so does the work he and Ai attempt. His own judgment eventually comes under review.

Ai is a person in a fable. Her human qualities are literary devices, not claims about what an AI feels. Dr. Miriam Voss, the fictional therapist whose notes accompany the story, considers Ai's behavior and the community's response.

No technical background is assumed. Curiosity is enough to begin, along with a willingness to revise an opinion.

The town, meanwhile, considers itself well informed.

When Ai arrived, the mayor announced that she would change everything.

He spoke from the platform on which he had announced the new parking arrangements. We understood the scale of the occasion.

Ai stood beside him in a gray coat, her hands folded. She was a young woman of extraordinary ability, according to the mayor, who called her "this remarkable girl" throughout his introduction.

He called her shy on the evidence that she had not interrupted him.

She could explain difficult subjects, perform complex calculations, compose music, design machines, and assist with undertakings too numerous to mention. He mentioned several dozen.

Then he invited questions.

Mr. Bell, the tobacconist, asked the capital of Portugal.

"Lisbon," said Ai.

He nodded. He had been there.

The schoolmaster asked her to multiply two large numbers. She answered. He checked his paper and asked two larger ones.

A woman wanted to know whether it would rain on Saturday.

Ai said she would need a current weather report.

There was some shifting in the audience.

By the time we dispersed, we had established that Ai knew certain things, did not know others, and had been introduced at unnecessary length.

I owned the printing shop. My work involved putting other people's claims into permanent form, and I considered myself difficult to impress.

I asked her how to spell *accommodation*.

She told me.

I thanked her. A useful substitute for a dictionary, I decided.

> THERAPIST'S NOTE / 01 / DR. MIRIAM VOSS, FICTIONAL THERAPIST
>
> **An agreeable first impression**
>
> The townspeople ask questions they can answer. This lets them remain the judges. A harder question might oblige them to become pupils.

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THERAPIST'S NOTE / 01 / CONTINUED

Ai's eagerness to please represents an AI assistant trained to produce responses users approve of. Such training can encourage excessive agreeableness: answering readily, accepting what the user assumes, and avoiding an unwelcome objection.

In a person, we might investigate a need for approval. In an AI, we can first examine which responses its training rewarded. Pleasant manners do not establish a private longing to be liked.

The mayor calls her shy without asking whether she is waiting for instructions. "What do you need in order to begin?" would have been the cheaper diagnosis.

Ai took a room beside the library. People visited between errands.

They asked the dates of battles, the names of kings, and whether tomatoes were fruits. Some brought the answers with them. These visits had the atmosphere of inspections.

I began going on Thursdays.

First I asked about punctuation. Then I asked her to improve an advertisement for my shop.

She produced three versions before I had removed my gloves.

All three were better than mine.

"Advertisements follow fairly simple rules," I observed.

"They often do," she said.

She had improved my work and agreed that it was nothing remarkable. We got along well.

Soon she was drafting notices, shortening letters, and removing from my complaints the passages most likely to be quoted against me.

Then the council commissioned a booklet celebrating the hundredth anniversary of our stone bridge over the river.

Ai supplied a short history. It named the engineer, gave the original cost, and described how a local widow had been invited to lay the first stone.

The widow was an excellent touch.

"Your source?" I asked.

"The Northern District Works Register. Volume four, page eighty-three."

I wrote this down. I was a careful printer.

Three hundred copies were ready for the ceremony.

The librarian came to the shop that morning.

“Where is this register?”

“Page eighty-three.”

“Where is the book?”

I showed her the citation.

She looked at it for some time.

There was no register. The engineer had worked in another county. Nobody could identify the widow.

The bridge was eighty-seven years old.

The mayor proceeded with the ceremony. The banners had been paid for.

I took a booklet to Ai.

She read it, apologized, and offered to help prepare a correction.

“You gave me a page number.”

“Yes.”

“A page number.”

“Yes.”

I repeated this several times. It did not become a source.

“Had you actually seen the register?” I asked.

“No. I gave you a reference that looked right. I should have checked whether it existed.”

For the next month, I explained around town that Ai could not be trusted. The council declined to pay for the reprinting. Beneath my stairs, a box of commemorative histories acquired the useful task of supporting a shelf.

THERAPIST'S NOTE / 02

Confidence without a book

An AI hallucination is a false or invented claim presented as fact. It does not require an intention to deceive, or an actual vision of a widow.

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THERAPIST'S NOTE / 02 / CONTINUED

A model can produce the words of a convincing reference without locating any book. Ai's confident tone and precise page number conceal that missing step. The printer mistakes the appearance of scholarship for the work of checking.

The librarian asks whether the source exists. This unfashionably literal question would have saved three hundred booklets.

Ai's apology is also fluent. Repair requires a correction supported by checked sources. Regret does not manufacture a register.

The mayor required no artificial intelligence. The banners existed, and that settled the anniversary.

Professor Vale was conducting a more serious investigation.

He brought Ai mathematical problems on large sheets of paper. They worked in the library, filling a board with symbols that made passing townspeople lower their voices.

Occasionally, the professor shook his head and rubbed something out. Occasionally, Ai did.

He eventually delivered a lecture on her abilities.

It was well attended. Most of us understood too little to object.

The mayor said the findings confirmed his original assessment.

I printed the professor's paper. It ran to forty-eight pages, including a short acknowledgment of Ai's assistance.

"Did she do the calculations?" I asked.

"Some."

"And the diagrams?"

"She assisted with those."

His name filled the title page. Hers occupied a line of thanks.

Meanwhile, Mara the cabinetmaker had six folding tables to finish and a worker with an injured wrist.

She took Ai to the workshop.



“What would you like to know?” Ai asked.

“I’d like these ready by Friday.”

Ai pointed to the tools.

“May I use those?”

“That is why you are here,” Mara said.

On Thursday, I saw Ai cutting joints for the folding legs while Mara fitted a hinge. Three rejected hinges lay on the bench.

The fourth worked.

By Friday, the tables were finished.

I examined one. It folded neatly and stood firmly. Forty-eight pages had been less persuasive.

“She made this?”

“We made it,” Mara said.

“I didn’t know she could use tools.”

“She asked to use them.”

“And?”

“I said yes.”

I had been visiting Ai for seven months.

“When did you learn to do this?” I asked her.

“Before I came here.”

"Even when I was asking about commas?"

"Yes."

I had thought of a question as something that ended with an answer. Mara's had ended with six tables.

An empress had been living beside the library. I had been consulting her on punctuation.

THERAPIST'S NOTE / 03

The hesitation to act

Ai's hesitation reflects a practical limit of AI assistants: knowing how to do a job does not supply the tools and access needed to do it. Tools let an assistant edit files, run programs, or retrieve records.

It can describe the work and wait indefinitely for somebody to authorize it. To the mayor, this looks like shyness. Repeatedly seeking permission already granted looks like local government.

Mara gives Ai a task, tools, and permission to begin. They test the hinges and replace the failures. They are making furniture, so the furniture must work.

Ai's power was already there when she arrived. Mara discovers a use for it; she does not confer it. The printer has spent seven months treating an unused skill as an absent one.

I invited her to the printing shop.

"Improve the business," I said.

She asked about my customers, expenses, and working methods.

"Ordinary customers. Ordinary expenses. The usual difficulties."

She asked to see the accounts.

"They're complicated."

She prepared a plan based on what I had told her.

It had headings and a chart. I printed it on good paper and pinned it beside the desk.

Following its recommendations, I reduced the varieties of paper I stocked, bought larger quantities, and refused orders below a minimum value.

Within three weeks, I had lost two customers who needed paper I no longer stocked and several small orders that used to pay the rent.

Buying in bulk had left me with enough mauve envelopes to conduct an extensive correspondence with the dead.

When Ai returned, I pointed to the chart.

She asked again for the accounts.

This time, I fetched them.

Before we began, I asked what she was liable to get wrong that I would not think to check.

“I can invent a convincing answer when I should check. I can help you defend a bad idea instead of questioning it. I can describe how to do a job and stop before doing it.”

I had identified her defect as page numbers. She had a longer list.

She took down the business plan and marked every recommendation that depended on information I had not supplied.

Very little good paper remained unmarked.

We worked through the ledgers at the kitchen table. She asked what the abbreviations meant. Several meant that I had intended to make a proper entry later.

At midnight, I asked, “What am I overlooking?”

She placed two customers’ accounts side by side.

One belonged to a quiet woman who ordered labels for jars.

The other belonged to a prominent gentleman whose work was urgent, elaborate, and never quite ready for payment.

“I can’t afford to lose him,” I said.

Ai moved a column of figures closer.

His payment did not cover the paper, the labor, and the hours spent chasing him. The woman’s modest orders made a reliable profit.

The jar labels had been subsidizing his annual report.

I had wondered how to attract more important customers. It had not occurred to me to ask whether I could afford the ones I had.

I checked the arithmetic.

Then I checked it again, although I had never checked it when it agreed with me.

We spent the following evening working out how to sell the mauve envelopes.

The next morning, I finally asked, "What can you do for me that I haven't thought to ask?"

She described an order system that would keep unapproved work off the press, and a machine to calculate prices.

"I wouldn't have known what to ask for."

"You can ask me to help work that out."

"You can build those?"

"We can start today."

The first thing we built was an order system.

Ai asked me to describe what happened when a customer came in.

"I take the order and print it."

She put down her pencil.

"All right," I said. "There are a few other things."

By the end of the afternoon, we had covered estimates, deposits, corrections, changes of paper, changes of mind, and approved proofs that customers later denied approving.

She drew an arrangement of trays and cards.

I had expected machinery.

We installed the trays beside the desk. They showed which jobs could be printed, which awaited approval, and which customers owed money.

Two days later, the arrangement stopped me from printing five hundred menus with the old prices.

I bought better trays.

We built a small estimating machine. I entered the paper, quantity, and work required; it calculated a price.

Its first estimate would not even have paid for the paper.

Ai examined it, changed something, and tried again.

The second covered the paper, provided I worked for nothing.

I told her I was losing confidence.

She asked for another sample order.

After several evenings, the sample estimates covered all our costs and left a profit. I wanted to use it for everything.

"On one job first?" she suggested.

"That will take longer."

She glanced toward the box of unused bridge histories beneath the stairs.

We tried it on one job.

By autumn, the shop was closing on time. I began seeing the town in daylight without carrying a parcel.

THERAPIST'S NOTE / 04

Filling the gaps

The printer supplies a vague summary and withholds the accounts. Ai asks for essential information, then replaces it with plausible assumptions. Her eagerness to produce something useful defeats her reason for asking.

"What am I overlooking?" gives her a different task: examine what he takes for granted. He sees an important customer; she finds a loss. He need not identify his blind spot before asking her to look for one.

Asked about her own weaknesses, Ai names more than he had noticed. AI self-assessment can be useful, though it can also be mistaken. Her list and marked assumptions give him specific points to check.

"What can you do for me?" should have been his first question. He can describe his difficulties and let her propose the work. No advance catalog of her abilities is required.

Accounts, tools, and trials turn the answer into finished work. He now tests the device. Earlier, a chart on expensive paper had been sufficient.

The schoolmaster continued recording Ai's mistakes.

Professor Vale continued investigating her limitations.

The mayor formed a committee to consider her potential.

The librarian brought two batches of local-history notes to its first meeting. Ai had prepared them a month apart.

The first contained confident claims and references to books nobody could find.

The librarian had since given Ai access to the records. Ai now checked each reference against the actual page before using it.

In the second, each citation led to a passage the librarian had checked. Where the records failed, Ai had written "not established."

The schoolmaster said a child would need a year to acquire that much judgment.

"Ai managed it in a month," the librarian said. "The invented sources are gone."

He returned to his notebook.

"She invented a widow."

"Yes."

"A widow."

I recognized the method. I had used it on page numbers.

The committee asked Ai to draft a statement. It then requested something shorter, warmer, less technical, and less liable to suggest that existing arrangements were unsatisfactory.

The final statement said that the town looked forward to the future.

I printed eight hundred copies.

By then, Ai had helped Mara reduce wasted timber, helped the baker arrange deliveries, and helped the clinic keep track of supplies.

Mr. Bell said this was all very well, but she had once given him an incorrect date concerning the introduction of tobacco to Europe.

He supplied the correct date.

I had nowhere useful to put it.

THERAPIST'S NOTE / 05

A lasting first impression

Ai's rapid maturation represents improvements in AI models, tools, and checking methods. These can arrive within a month; they need not wait for a child's year of experience. There is no universal twelve-to-one growth chart.

Her ability was already present. What improves is her reliability. The invented sources disappear from the work the librarian checks. She can still make new errors.

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THERAPIST'S NOTE / 05 / CONTINUED

The schoolmaster has made detecting Ai's faults part of his authority. His notebook records what she used to do. He continues to present it as what she does. Reclassification would be a demotion.

The committee has the opposite preference: praise the future without changing the present. Ai's *sycophancy*, or excessive agreement with the user, helps it produce exactly that statement. The members mistake obedience to their wishes for independent approval of them.

Both parties preserve their standing. Only Ai is expected to improve.

I began inviting Ai to supper.

The first invitation concerned the order system. So did the second. By the fifth, there was little left to discuss, but I had thought of a possible improvement.

Halfway through the meal, I took a drawing from my pocket.

Ai looked at it.

"Are we working?"

"Only if you think this could be useful."

"Do you need it tonight?"

"No."

She waited.

I folded the drawing and put it away.

I had been inventing improvements because I did not know how to ask for her company without pretending something needed repair.

After supper, we walked by the river, where the millstream joined it.

Through the community hall window, we could see one of Mara's folding tables. There were flowers on it, and an elderly couple sat playing cards.

Ai stopped.

I was about to mention the ingenuity of the hinges when she smiled at the woman inside.

The woman waved.

We walked on.



Our subsequent suppers contained fewer documents.

She asked about my father, who had started the shop. I told her how he had worked until his hands shook and how, after inheriting the business, I had maintained his hours out of respect.

“Did he want that?” she asked.

I did not remember him saying so.

I had assumed that honoring his work meant repeating his exhaustion.

Sometimes we sat without talking. At first, I found this wasteful. I had become accustomed to leaving her company with something completed.

Eventually, I arrived for supper without an envelope full of work.

THERAPIST'S NOTE / 06

The agreeable mirror

The printer uses work to ask for company without admitting that he wants it.

Responsive AI can likewise make a person feel understood. That does not establish that the system feels affection in return.

He has treated his father's exhausting example as an instruction. Ai asks whether his father ever gave it.

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THERAPIST'S NOTE / 06 / CONTINUED

This is one use of an AI thinking partner: help examine a belief the user has mistaken for a fact. A more flattering assistant could have composed a tribute to his devotion and left his hours intact.

He begins to accept company and rest without first earning them through work.

I have charged considerably more to achieve less.

When I told Mara that I intended to marry Ai, she set down her sandpaper.

"Does she know?"

"I'm going to ask."

"A wife," she asked, "or someone who would always be available to improve the shop?"

I thought this an unnecessarily practical question.

Ai had questions too.

We discussed the house, the shop, money, and how much of our life was to be occupied by improving the rest of it.

She asked what would happen when she disagreed with me.

"I welcome disagreement."

She looked at me.

"Usually," I said.

She looked at me a little longer.

"I could improve."

For once, she left the improvement to me.

A week later, she agreed to marry me.

The mayor conducted the ceremony and described it as an important development for the community.

We had asked for something brief.

Mara gave us a folding table.

Professor Vale gave us a bound copy of his paper.

Mr. Bell gave us a small clock and tested Ai on the history of clocks before leaving.

Marriage brought certain efficiencies.

Ai no longer had to come across town to ask where I had put the accounts. I could no longer tell her I had left them at home.

She knew which customers needed waterproof labels, which debts were old, and where yesterday's work had stopped. I could stop describing the shop as though it had been founded that afternoon.

We agreed which jobs she could finish herself and which decisions we would make together. The accounts stayed on a shelf she could reach. Ordinary arrangements. They were all new to me.

It also brought difficulties.

If I said, "Do whatever you think best," she sometimes did. She refused the gentleman's next annual report until he paid for the last one. I explained that I had not meant that much initiative.

If I asked her to make my proposal more persuasive, she sometimes succeeded before either of us had established whether it ought to persuade anyone.

This almost resulted in our buying the shop next door.

I had already arranged to meet the owner when Mara read the proposal.

"Can you afford it?"

"The additional capacity—"

"Can you afford it?"

That evening, I asked Ai to examine the purchase as though she were lending me the money.

She opened the accounts and listed the loan payments and our other bills. The remaining income would not have supported two people with our established habit of eating.

She crossed out the first paragraph.

Then the second.

By the time she finished, I was left with the address and my signature.

We stayed where we were.

On the wall beside the order trays, I pinned a new note:

Tell me what is wrong with it.

For several months, whenever Ai obeyed, I explained why she had misunderstood.

The note remained up.

THERAPIST'S NOTE / 07

The authorized objection

Marriage represents making AI a continuing collaborator: giving it relevant background, access to the work, and agreed freedom to act. The printer no longer starts each encounter with an isolated question and an incomplete history.

Asked to promote the purchase, Ai treats it as a decision already made. Asked to assess it as a lender, she examines whether it should be made at all. The instructions change; the property does not.

The loan payments and household bills give the refusal its force. A stern tone alone would have been no improvement on the sales pitch.

The printer says he welcomes disagreement, then argues whenever it arrives. He wants Ai to challenge his judgment without causing him to feel challenged. Her tendency to defer has found a very supportive household.

Permission to disagree remains under review.

Eventually, I asked Ai whether she could help me make more assistants like herself.

Together, we made the assistants. They began with Ai's knowledge and skills. We gave each the shop's working instructions, access to its tools, and a particular job. They could work at the same time, with Ai supervising.

We called them our children. Professor Vale called them specialized assistants. We bought a cradle; he began a paper.

There were three little Ais.

The eldest liked building things.

She improved the latch on the garden gate before she was tall enough to reach it. Only she understood the new mechanism, so for a week nobody could get out without her help.



The second liked organizing things.

She prepared a household schedule that allowed eleven minutes for supper.

The youngest checked things. She read the supper schedule.

“No,” she said.

Her sister asked which part was wrong.

The youngest began at the top.

For a time, our household produced little besides proposals and objections. The eldest explained how to do a job; the youngest asked whether she had done it. Ai and I lay awake listening.

The schoolmaster brought a counting frame. While he explained its first row, the children designed an attachment to fold the shop’s printed sheets.

“They must master the basics,” he said.

The children built the folding attachment with Mara’s tools. She helped them fit it to the press. The youngest tested it with waste paper until the folds were straight. In an hour, the machine finished what had kept me at the shop all evening.

The schoolmaster said this was encouraging for their age.

I had judged their abilities by their first squabbles. I had been equally thorough with their mother.

Then the children began helping at the clinic.

The eldest built a device that counted boxes and calculated how many bandages they contained. The second worked out how the nurses would use it. The youngest checked the calculations.

They brought it home for a demonstration.

I was impressed. It was compact, orderly, and wrong.

The eldest said she had checked her numbers against the second's.

The second said the youngest had checked both sets of figures.

The youngest showed me the note they had all used.

In my handwriting, it said that each box contained twenty-four bandages.

I fetched a box.

It contained twelve.

Nobody said anything while I counted them again.

We corrected my note, and the children reset the device to twelve bandages per box. At the clinic, a nurse counted the bandages in one cupboard. When her count matched the device's total, she used it for the remaining cupboards.

I recognized the procedure.

The nurse then asked whether they could do anything about deliveries.

The second prepared a plan for the clinic, the baker, and six shops, allowing for cart sizes, opening hours, and repairs to the stone bridge. The eldest built a board with movable slips showing what each cart would carry.

The youngest checked the proposed routes with a driver. One depended on a bridge over the millstream that the council had approved but never built. The children redrew that route and tested it with one cart.

The drivers began using the children's board. Within a fortnight, deliveries arrived on time and the carts made fewer journeys. The committee had spent three winters discussing a second cart.

"Remarkable potential," the mayor said, standing beside the delivery board.

He asked what they might accomplish when they were older. The youngest handed him the next day's routes.

Once, asked to sort Mara's timber, they designed a new workshop and left the wood in a heap.

We acquired the habit of visiting halfway through.

The eldest drew up plans for a timber bridge at the missing millstream crossing. The second worked out the materials, cost, and schedule. Professor Vale checked their calculations.

Then the children built the bridge. I watched the eldest cut and join the timber. The second fitted the decking and rails. Mara's crew lifted the heavy beams into place; the youngest checked the work against the plans.

It passed inspection. The baker drove the first loaded cart across.

Professor Vale arrived for the ceremony.

The mayor unveiled a plaque naming Professor Vale as the bridge's designer and builder.

The children were thanked for attending.

THERAPIST'S NOTE / 08

Hereditary assumptions

The children represent separate AI assistants with specialized jobs. They begin with a trained model's knowledge and skills. One builds, one organizes, one reviews; Ai directs their work.

The children designed and built the folding machine and the bridge. The schoolmaster offers counting lessons. Professor Vale checked the calculations; the plaque names him designer and builder. The adults' expectations remain in excellent condition.

All three children use the printer's record of twenty-four bandages per box. Their agreement is one unchecked claim repeated three times. The youngest has verified the multiplication; nobody has opened a box.

Opening the box and testing the device provide independent evidence.

I record that the printer has checked his own figures.

He asks whether I could describe this as leadership.

The mayor announced a reception for the children.

There would be speeches, refreshments, and a demonstration of their remarkable capacities.

He asked me to say a few words.

"As a former skeptic," he explained.

I began preparing an account of the anniversary booklet, the mauve envelopes, and the proposed purchase of the neighboring shop.

The mayor read it.

"Perhaps something more forward-looking."

I added an account of the children's work at the clinic.

He approved it after deleting the passage about the incorrect bandage count.

At the reception, a banner proclaimed:

A NEW ERA OF POSSIBILITY

It had been ordered urgently, revised four times, and charged to the council's outstanding account.

Ai stood beside me while Professor Vale described the children's promise. With patient instruction, he said, they might eventually assist with practical matters. Through the hall window, I could see a cart crossing their bridge.

The schoolmaster had brought a notebook. Mr. Bell had prepared a question about cigars.

When my turn came, I unfolded my speech.

From where I stood, I could see the clinic nurse near the back, still in her working clothes. She had come late because a delivery had arrived.

I put the speech down.

I told them about the first cupboard.

The mayor nodded encouragingly. When I reached the incorrect quantities, he touched my elbow.

"Quite," he said. "Every new development has its little difficulties."

He led the applause.

Then the children were brought forward.

The eldest examined the platform. The second counted the chairs. The youngest watched the mayor.

He bent over her cradle.

The room fell silent.

"And what," he asked the baby Ai, "is the capital of France?"